Dark Temptation

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Dark Temptation

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Summary





Notes

More work inspired on Frye7? Always. Huge thanks, go read that great quality content.
This time, based on *Smirking eyes and claws of ice*, but has a different twist on the end because that's how the idea came around like, the first quarter of the fic. I kind of mentioned it to you in a comment, so you may figure out how this is going to end haha, not the whole idea tho, so it doesn't really count as spoiler, I promise!

Besides, I once entertained an idea similar to this (which I won't specify now to avoid spoilers, so I'll make sure to add it in the final comments, heh). Not the part of the corruption, but rather something slightly similar to what happens in Frye's fic plus the twist I'm giving to it. So now I had an amazing idea, plus a great solution to the only plot issue I had.

It's funny because, last time, I had just seen a prompt that was exactly like the topic of Frye's *Lost*, so when reading it and getting the idea for *You Were Mine to Kill* it felt like a cosmic order to write it. Now, the literal day after having discussed that "corrupted Au", I go and read that fic with dark Bloom, aka, corrupted Bloom, and immediately thought "well, what if Casta…" and again it felt like a cosmic order XD
And, as if to reinforce such order, I discovered Tippen's Dark Glimmer series, and WOW! Please, I was itching to finally write this (and mega hype in the comments XD) I also recommend going to read it, you won't regret it!

I hope you like it, Frye! (^_^)/
Without further ado, please enjoy!

Ahem, I'd like to add a little announcement: Meet my dopplergänger, midnight_rambles, who also had a corrupted Casta idea but didn't finish it (hopefully you'll do so!), and I'd also like to promote this beauty she posted the other day TT^TT
End of the announcement!

- Inspired by Smirking eyes and claws of ice by Frye7
- Inspired by [Restricted Work] by TippenFunkaport

It’s all too good to be trusted

Chapter Summary

A failed plan, a lost shadow spy, and a corrupted sorceress.

"You create your own demons", and that's exactly what Shadow Weaver has just done.

Chapter Notes

Remember how, in *You Were Mine to Kill*, SW was obsessed with defeating Casta herself and that?
Well, as you may have noticed from the series name "Cycles", I'm making this a series of life cycles in which these two keep reincarnating, as if trapped by SW's obsession. These all take place in this canon divergence in which Catra left the Horde with Adora at the same time and Micah wasn't captured or anything. So, in that other fic, the woman was solely obsessed with Casta, not with the girls anymore, but why?
Here it is: from this life she carried the need to beat her, her obsession with her too (because here she didn't know her from before, as you will see here). There's also *another* detail carried from here, related to what SW couldn't remember but that the scar on Casta's chin almost reminded her.
I will be writing that too, all of what happened and why SW doesn't remember it, and post is as part of the series, but from here you may guess by the end why SW doesn't remember that. Or not, but at least, once I post that, it will all make more sense than without this context.

My gods! Sorry for rambling so much! I hope you enjoy this!!
But before I forget: I made this playlist of songs that have inspired me castaweaver fics, and for this one, the perfect songs would be *Evil Night Together*, *Sadizm*, *Sick Like Me*, *Mz. Hyde*, *Poison*, *Bad Romance*, *In Flames*, *Out of My Life*, and *Only Us*. (If you think those are too many, well, get ready for the +40 songs in the playlist ahah)

Now yes, go ahead!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was still impossible to find and catch either Adora or Catra. Shadow Weaver had spent plenty of power trying to recover them, barely able to keep convincing Hordak of their

indispensability, yet still managed as much due to how much of a disappointment most squads had proven to be.

Her best shot now was to use her shadow spies to trick them and finally catch both of them. After the defeat at the Sea Gate, she had used her scouts merely to follow and give different Force Captains indications to try and ambush them; the only result had been capturing Princess Entrapta, and when she proved useful to Hordak with her technology savvy, the princess was given access to whatever she wanted, including a communication system she managed to, somehow, connect to the Rebellion.

While Shadow Weaver had no idea how she achieved so, she tried to get into Hordak's good graces by warning him about it, but the princess had only explained to her *friends* she had everything she needed there so she "would be staying here for a while". And so, within a week, she absolutely got into her nerves, and the dark sorceress needed now, more than ever, to capture *her* rogue wards, before Hordak finally decided they weren't worth spending any more resources on.

This time, she decided to finally use her spies to trick them; the best way would be to make them feel rejected by the Rebellion and make them consider the girls traitors, so she had her spies follow them until they were in a kingdom where she could execute her plan.

She noticed them on their way to Mystacor and it felt perfect: she could do it all together. She'd deceive everyone, mess with their heads until the girls were pretty much accused of everything that went wrong, and if she managed to make them feel rejected by the time the lunar lenses recharge began, that would be the perfect moment to mess the ceremony, break Mystacor's defenses, and *finally* take revenge. All of this would result in recovering her wards at long last, grant the Horde a defeat for which Hordak would recognize her prowess, and grant her the revenge she had spent decades wanting to get.

And so, an unexpected issue ruined it all.

On their way to Mystacor, as they were on the floating boulder and about to cross the shield, Catra felt so motion sick she almost fell off; Shadow Weaver could only watch, enraged, as Princess Glimmer teleported them all back to the cliff where they were moments ago. She yelled loudly, infuriated, moments before Hordak decided to "check on her progress". The dark sorceress could barely disguise her frustration.

—Report, Shadow Weaver. Have you managed *anything* useful this time?

—I need but a few hours, My Lord— she excused herself.

—Your focus is misplaced. You must stop looking for the rogue soldiers. You're distracted— he sentenced, severely.

—I- I am not… looking for them— she lied. She quickly looked into the basin where swirls moved slowly and saw that her shadow spy, still latched to the floating boulder, had just entered Mystacor. —I have taken a chance to infiltrate one of my spies into the floating kingdom of the sorcerers. Today, a ceremony will be held to reinforce the shield that protects

them; I will make it fail and Mystacor will be ours for the taking, those sorcerers have no fighting skills, they have remained too oblivious of the war. They shall be easy prey.

—Perfect. Finally a sound plan from you— he let out, sounding quite satisfied. While Shadow Weaver felt deeply offended, she knew better than to complain in any way and elected to remain silent. —I shall review the results at nightfall.

As soon as he was gone, she let her rage out once again. Now, this *has* to work. She had no more options. While half her plan could no longer be done, if she managed to take control of Mystacor, it would certainly allow her to have the upper hand during her future plans, to finally catch them. All she had to do to beat these fools, was merely have her imp enter the Lunarium and disrupt the magic that should recharge the lunar lenses. Her black magic would do the rest.

But she made a fatal mistake: She underestimated the Head Sorceress.

Seemingly bad at casting, she was instead quite skillful in this particular kind of magic, more defensive than anything else, and she lost control over her imp as the sorceress restrained it within her. The ceremony was fulfilled again, and Shadow Weaver lost her only advantage; unable to know what had happened, she decided to leave before Hordak could find and punish her.

And yet, as she nears her room, her attention is drawn by the voices of guards discussing what the scouts have found out.

—I mean, I can hardly believe it. Just *how* did it happen!? Did any of you see it?

—No, no. I told you. The scouts. They were so shocked they immediately told us when they arrived.

—But it makes no sense. Why would she…

—Wait!— one guard interrupted the other as their coms began beeping.

Both of them turned their coms on and frenetic voices came out in such a chaotic way it seemed like they were being attacked or such.

—*It-it's impossible!*

—*We-we need- What do we do!?*

—*She's scary, ve-very scary. Do-do we…*

—*We have to take her to Hordak!*

The guards looked at each other and ran to the entrance, needing to see what was happening. On the other hand, Shadow Weaver remained there, unable to move. It all sounded so familiar she was left thinking.

Wasn't this the same panic she had caused when she first appeared?

These troops were still so pathetic…

And what were those guards talking about just earlier?

She saw a cadet from the scouts' team walking down the corridor and immediately stepped in their way.

—Sh-Shadow Weaver— they let out, immediately saluting.

—I heard the scouts have some *shocking* news. Care to clarify, cadet?— she requested, with a tone that made it sound more like an order.

—O-of course— they complied. —We were sent to scout some Rebellion camps, and we heard almost everyone speak about the same: She-Ra had been urgently called to deal with a situation in Mystacor, something about the Head Sorceress going crazy but, whatever that meant, it had already ended before she could do anything; in fact, nothing seemed to have happened at all, the woman had simply disappeared. And then… on our way back, we sped by someone… we're almost sure that's the sorceress they were speaking about. But it's so…

—A sorceress, you say? How did she look?

It couldn't *really* be the Head Sorceress who had somehow severed her control over the shadow spy, right? Unless…

—I believe that must be the one who has just arrived. After all, she seemed to be coming this way.

—That will be all, cadet. You're dismissed.

The dark sorceress made her way to the main hall; whoever it was, would surely be taken to Hordak. She had to remain hidden so he wouldn't see her at all, but almost revealed herself out of shock.

It *was* that sorceress. But at the same time, she looked nothing like her. Between the lack of crown, her hair loose, and the pinkish marks visible on her hands… she looked like anything but that pathetic woman she had seen through her spy. There was no way…

Her spy.

Did it really corrupt her!? Was this the effect of dark magic in her system!?

While Hordak welcomed her, seemingly pleased with a new addition to his troops, Shadow Weaver focused on the sorceress. It was evident that those marks represented still-reversible damage, nothing like her own scars, yet the sleeves covered just how far up they had crawled.

—Shadow Weaver!— Hordak roared. —Come to the front. You may want to meet our new member.

New member!? She had come to join the Horde, and Hordak had *already* accepted her?

—Yes, my Lord.

—I suppose this was because of your plan— he began. —Not quite what was expected, but this *is* a way of weakening the floating kingdom, indeed— he commented. —From now on, you have someone else to worry about. Forget the rogue cadets; focus on contributing to the Horde, or I'll have to reevaluate your place here.

His statements sent chills down her spine, yet she managed to hide it and just bowed, complying. Before everyone was dismissed, Castaspella looked back at her; the sorceress' wicked expression surprised Shadow Weaver enough to force her to take a step back.

Who was this person!? And why was she so much of an obvious threat to her and everything she had worked to obtain since joining the Horde?

Castaspella walked past her and left the room, leaving the dark sorceress extremely shocked for a while. There was no doubt: she was now the competition, and Hordak would make them fight for the status Shadow Weaver had held for the past decades.

This wouldn't be fun. *At all*.

And so it begins: within hours, the sorceress was feeling the sheer pressure of competence as she kept underestimating Castaspella. The woman had managed to settle many issues for different divisions of the Horde, from the strategists to the soldiers, scouts, and even the crafters of weapons and armor; Hordak kept making a point of how much better than Shadow Weaver she already was, how her focus was on the right topics, and that made her grow desperate.

She couldn't let it happen, not after so many years of sacrifice. She couldn't let anyone, especially not *her*, take her power away. All the sorcerers had been so irrelevant in the war, even Micah who merely supported from the back after nearly dying some years before; she was not used to going against other magic users, and especially not someone like this woman.

Everyone in Mystacor had always been *so* pathetic… except Micah of course, but he wasn't part of the Sorcerers Guild anymore. How could it be that, now, she had accidentally given this woman exactly what was needed for any of those fools to rival her?

—Agh!

Shadow Weaver screamed, enraged, practically stabbing the Black Garnet with her claws as, once again, she went to absorb as much power as she could. But she was, perhaps, too desperate to realize this time she was taking more power than ever; it was nightfall, she had recharged about five or six times already, yet made no progress at all, which only made her return for more. And now it was too much even for her.

The gem embedded in her mask glowed bright, a blinding red light stronger than the garnet's even, a warning that illuminated the whole chamber.

It began hurting her, but the dark sorceress ignored it, madly focused on obtaining as much power as possible. She ignored the ache of her already-weakened muscles, the sting of the energy drain this meant, the burning sensations flowing through her scars as she forced the power into her, the darkening of her vision and numbing of her senses in general.

She ignored it all until she passed out of exhaustion.

The chamber fell silent and it went dark. Mere minutes later, a curious Castaspella peeked into the chamber, only to find the woman passed out on the floor, the gemstone opaque, and the gem in Shadow Weaver's mask glowing so faintly it was obvious what had happened.

She hummed, amused, thinking aloud —This is quite convenient, I guess.

Smirking, she laughed faintly and walked in.

Shadow Weaver woke up feeling worse than ever before. She had no idea what had happened, in fact, she had no idea where she was, or what time it was. Being in such a poor state, she hardly remembered who she was.

When she managed to open her eyes, there was a woman staring down at her with a wicked smile. Was she hallucinating maybe?

Her face looked familiar, pinkish scars surrounded her brown eyes, and it took her a moment too long to recognize the Sorcerer's Guild attire.

Right.

The Head Sorceress she accidentally corrupted.

She had come to the Horde, turned her life into a nightmare, and Hordak wouldn't stop nagging her about how bad her performance is compared to that of Castaspella.

Once instinct finally kicked in, Shadow Weaver pushed the woman away and sat back on her pillows, supporting herself on the wall, her fear hidden by her mask.

The sorceress simply cackled at her reaction, she wasn't really expecting that, and it's evident she had given her quite a scare. But that was, in fact, better than any of the reactions she had imagined.

—For the "most powerful" sorceress, as you claim to be, that was quite poor from you. One would think you'd know better than to exert yourself to such an extent— she mocked her.

Shadow Weaver blinked a few times before asking —What are you talking about? What happened to me!?

Castaspella leaned back against the wall in front of her bed, noticing —So you don't recall the past few hours, I suppose. Well…—. She chuckled and looked away, smirking. —I suppose I've been quite a nuisance for you today; you kept going back to get power from the

Garnet, and couldn't handle how much you tried to siphon from it, could you?— she explained, sardonically. —Oh, but lucky you, I brought you here before Lord Hordak could see you.

Her stare made Shadow Weaver shiver; that sounded so much like a threat. It made her blood boil. How dared she!? There was no way she'd let Castaspella blackmail her like that.

And yet…

Immediately after having spoken so sardonically, the sorceress' expression changed drastically. She pondered for a minute: there isn't much stopping her now from doing "improper" things or indulging in "inappropriate" behaviours; she had nothing to lose and might as well spoil herself a little. She pushed herself off the wall and approached Shadow Weaver with something akin to a seductive behaviour, an offering, one could say.

Or was it, in fact, her trying to seduce the dark sorceress?

Shadow Weaver was so shocked she couldn't stop Castaspella before she pinned her down on the mattress, and it became clear what her intentions were. She wasn't sure what she was expecting, but it was definitely *not* the faint kisses under her jaw.

Castaspella merely kissed the exposed skin right under her mask, teasingly, yet not daring to go any further, as if expecting her permission, but the dark sorceress couldn't bear such delicate touch anymore. Shadow Weaver raised her hands to grab the woman, push her around and be on top instead.

She took off her mask, tossed it away and, nearly breathless, let out —Curse you.

Right after, she leaned down to kiss Castaspella in a less gentle manner, yet the sorceress seemed to welcome it all the same, and only pressed on, craving for more. Perhaps it *could* be fun after all.

Hours passed. It was perhaps the middle of the night, early morning maybe, at the Horde it was always difficult to know. Shadow Weaver woke up, unsure of when she had fallen asleep or even gotten into bed in the first place, and noticed her body extremely sore. *Everywhere*.

Memories flooded her mind: from bites to scratches, tight restraining and maddening touches. That couldn't possibly be true, could it?

And yet, there she was.

Much to her surprise, she turned her face to the right and found the sorceress sleeping soundly by her side, her hair a mess, and those dark magic corruption marks.

It was all true: the woman had been corrupted, left Mystacor, joined the Horde, and became her worst nightmare, only to end up giving her the most satisfying night she had ever had.

It was simply insane.

Shadow Weaver stared at her for a while: those corruption marks had barely crawled up to half her forearms and were a faint pinkish color, meaning the damage was still reversible, hence, she hadn't used that much black magic, presumably just to teleport to the Fright Zone, just like she herself had done decades ago.

And now this all made her nostalgic; she hated it, but couldn't help recalling what had happened. Thinking about what her sweet talented Micah would think about this made her snicker sardonically: he'd hate every bit of it, blame her for it, which wouldn't exactly be wrong, and probably do something really reckless to try and get his sister back.

Right, *His sister*.

She hadn't gotten much information on the Head Sorceress but *that* was one of the things she learnt, and she could barely believe it still.

How very ironic.

This was all extremely cynical, and part of her felt smugly delighted about it. However, she also doubted it all. It couldn't possibly be true. It was *too good* to be true. This had to be some plan of hers, even those lustful hours earlier; there was no other explanation.

It's all too good to be trusted.

Chapter End Notes

The end of this chapter is sponsored by "SW's trust issues go brrr" XD

Hhahah, sorry sorry; but, for real. The woman can't trust anything nor anyone. Of course she'd mistrust this too, and even more after *such* night. Remember her infamous "she distracts you"? It applies to her too hahah

However, what do you guys think? Are SW's instincts right? I want to see the debate unleash ahah

And, until tomorrow!

(Of course, you can always go read the, um, *hot* night these two had. Do mind the tags. I repeat: DO MIND THE TAGS)

Castahex

Chapter Summary

Castaspella is gone.
Castahex rises.
Now, the Horde has a new advantage.
And Shadow Weaver, a new nightmare.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

How had all of this happened?

Merely a few days had passed; this was even easier than she initially thought.

Castaspella now stood proudly in front of the screen where Hordak's image had appeared. There was no reason for her to be nervous at all, not anymore. She's now his "most valuable asset" and, as such, everything became easier, comfortable even.

Apparently, Shadow Weaver's behavior mixed much better with her calmness and complete control of her reactions; it had been key to gaining this advantageous position.

What's the point of having all that power if a mere fit of rage can cause everything to backfire?

No. She's nowhere near the dark sorceress' power, but she doesn't need to either. Any doubts she bore finally left her as she realized she had, in fact, chosen the best strategy.

—Status report! And you better have made some progress this time— Hordak demanded.

—Of course. We have made significant advancements in terms of weaponry and armor development. The soldiers have been more willing to join missions and our losses had halved, at the very least— Castaspella replied, taking the lead, knowing full well it would make Shadow Weaver seethe behind her.

—So say the statistics, yes. However, our missions haven't shown any improvement— he argued. —Our soldiers have been ambushed almost every time, our scouts are easily discovered and return empty-handed— he remarked. Then his sight focused on Shadow Weaver. —*You* are the one in charge of avoiding this; your spies are supposed to keep our soldiers informed of the Rebellion's position— he reminded her. —I gave you the necessary power for that. Why have you *not* done so!?

Shadow Weaver's surprise was evident and she found herself at a loss for words. She *herself* didn't know the answer; *what* had she been doing?

Before the dark sorceress could utter a word, Castaspella replied instead —Excuse me, Lord Hordak. I suppose that may be my fault. After all, I have been occupying the basin for hours the past days; while my contributions did help, perhaps we neglected the key role her spies play during missions. We shall correct that mistake.

—You better do, Castahex. I will *not* tolerate more errors of this kind— he immediately threatened. Then, addressing Shadow Weaver once again, he asked —Do you have *any* progress to report?

—I have, My Lord— she began, hating how humble she had to behave now. —I have been developing a new training program that will ensure our cadets are ready for field missions as soon as possible.

Hordak hummed, pondering for a moment, before finally saying —In that case, I expect results by the end of the week, and they better be good or you *will* lose your privileges, including the access to the Black Garnet. Understood?

—Yes, Lord Hordak.

As soon as his image was gone, Castaspella walked out of the room and Shadow Weaver immediately went after her. She managed to catch up and didn't hesitate to pin her against a wall, infuriated.

—What game are you playing!?— she inquired, trying not to shout yet sounding quite menacing. —First, you trick me, then save my neck!? I do *not* owe you for this, I won't ever be indebted to you in any way.

—That's what you think?— Castaspella asked, still looking quite smug. —How ungrateful you are— she complained with fake disappointment. —While I definitely tricked you to secure my current position, I'm not stupid. That runestone is keeping you alive, isn't it? So quit whining and enjoy the time I can buy you.

—So it's like that? You're not interested in competing with me, just wanted to secure a safe position, don't you, Castaspella?

—It's Castahex now, remember? At least in public— the sorceress pointed out with a mischievous tone and a smooth wink that took the woman by surprise.

—That name is still very ridiculous.

—You came up with it.

—I was making fun of you— Shadow Weaver complained, still not letting go of her.

—Well, your fun was useful this time— she mocked her. —Now, may I remind you we're not in your room? You better release me before someone finds us.

—Why do you care about that?

—If Hordak finds out, it will be obvious I'm not competing. He might catch up on the things I say or do to keep you safe— the sorceress argued. —Speaking of which, you may want to get the schedule of approved missions so you go help with your spies as he requested.

—You do not give me orders— she immediately replied, making Castaspella laugh daintily.

—It's just a piece of advice, Dear. Take it or leave it, you chose.

Her smirk and daring look, combined with that "dear", kept Shadow Weaver frozen for a moment. She slowly released her, even though she still couldn't shake her suspicions; there's nothing else for her to do here. She disappeared down the corridor, reluctantly following her suggestion, annoyed enough to dim all lights around her as she passed.

The sorceress kept her sight on her until the woman was gone, and then took a deep breath. For each thing that got easier by gaining Hordak over, here she kept making others far more difficult by trying to keep such a delicate balance between her affair and the façade she tried to maintain.

She couldn't stop thinking about how, for someone who had never played these games, she sure seemed to be doing perfectly, so it might simply be beginners' luck. What would she do once it runs out? She couldn't even decide whether indulging in this little dark temptation of hers should go on; the safest would be to terminate it, of course, but she knew it wouldn't change things: she'd still try to do everything in her power to make sure Hordak wouldn't take Shadow Weaver's only lifeline away from her, and she'd still *want* that woman madly, even more now that she got more than a taste from her.

Castaspella let out a sigh and went to continue with her tasks, finally convinced by one last thought: she's playing with fire, so she better not hesitate; if she burns, she might set others on fire as well.

Later that same day, she came across Shadow Weaver's cadets, all hurt and looking dispirited. She couldn't recall having heard their names, except, perhaps for the blond boy.

The three teens quickened the pace when they saw her, noticeably afraid, so she immediately called out —Kyle? Come here.

He froze in place while the other two kept walking without looking back, and had no choice but to obey. However, when he approached, the woman didn't seem either angry or as scary as expected. Instead, she seemed curious and perhaps concerned.

—Ye-yes, En-Enchantress?

Is *that* what she's being called by the lower ranks!?

Castaspella blinked a few times, making a huge effort to keep herself from cackling, and made sure her surprise wouldn't be noticed.

Serious, and as severe as possible, she requested —Care to explain what happened to your squad? You're not yet qualified for field missions, none of you should sustain this many injuries.

—It's- It's nothing. Just training. Yeah, just that— he stammered.

—Training? I suppose you mean Shadow Weaver's new program, right?— she asked. When he nodded, she insisted —What exactly happened? What has she done?

Kyle gulped, growing increasingly nervous, and looked down as he admitted —Well, she- she got angry because we couldn't fulfill the training expectations.

—By "got angry" I suppose you mean she delivered a punishment of sorts, right?—. He nodded. —Extra training?—. He nodded again. —Does this happen often?—. Another nod. —To all of you, or *just* you? It appears to me she's merciless with you compared to your comrades.

—I- I don't know— he began. —Perhaps I just- I don't have the strength for this. So- I think- She's the same with all of us but I can't escape her anger— he finally explained, with a nervous laugh.

She reflected for a moment, humming, before finally saying —I don't think there's much I can do about that, but I can, perhaps, deliver some… retribution—. Her tone was mischievous, there was even a glint of malice in her eyes. —Wouldn't you like that?

Kyle immediately looked back at her, shocked, and stammered again as he asked —You- You'd do that?—. She nodded, so he added —I- Why would you… do this for me?

Now *that* was a good question and, fortunately, she had already thought of an answer.

—Mostly because it's amusing to bother her— she laughed. —But, more seriously, I don't see why not. In this place you're all pretty much allowed to make justice for yourself, no?— she argued. —I suppose it would be a huge risk for you, taking into account what you said, so I better do it myself— she concluded, laughing once again.

Kyle looked away, shy and unaccustomed to such favor, letting out —Thank you so much.

Castaspella smiled proudly and, mocking Shadow Weaver a bit, told him —Don't hesitate to come to me for help, kid. *Someone* should take proper care of you and your friends for once.

By the time the dark sorceress arrived at her room, everyone in the Horde was either asleep or on guard duty; yellowish lights buzzed in every corridor, soon to be turned off, and the heat from the day of work warmed the whole place.

But not her room.

A chill atmosphere received her when she opened the door, absolute darkness engulfed the place, which wasn't normal but didn't exactly bother her, and as soon as she stepped in, the

door was closed.

—Who's there!?— she roared.

—Who do you think?

The dark sorceress wasn't yet used to that purring tone the woman sometimes managed.

—What kind of stunt are you trying to pull now?— she inquired.

—Aw, don't you like my pranks?— Castaspella mocked her, finally approaching her from behind. —I promise this one will be to your taste— she whispered, barely brushing her left ear. As her hands teased Shadow Weaver's clothes, she felt her shiver and giggled. —Too cold for your taste? Do you need me to *warm you up*?

—Did you freeze my room just to make that stupid joke?— the woman countered, trying her best to appear aloof. However, immediately after, she felt sheer cold crawling up her legs and hissed in pain. —What is this!?

—What you asked for— Castaspella replied, whispering again, yet letting go of her this time. —May your game begin, Dear.

Despite the darkness, Shadow Weaver could see her casually strolling towards the bed. The moment she laid down, the dark sorceress finally understood what she meant.

Of course, *exactly* what she had asked for.

—Well then, let it begin— she let out. Tendrils of dark magic leaked from under her clothes, reached the bed, and found the sorceress' body; she didn't resist as the warm shadows wrapped around her legs, focusing instead on having the cold of her spell increase. —We both know you're not talented enough to keep that up for long.

Normally, such a comment would easily affect Castaspella, but not this time, because *now* it meant she was already desperate enough to resort to this. So, instead, she chose to reply calmly and unsettle her instead.

—Is that so? In that case, I'll have to make sure I win as soon as possible, don't you think?— she mocked her. But that wasn't enough, and the woman was right; she had to use her advantage now, no matter how much she'd like to delay this. Perhaps, next time, she could just let her win instead. —Ah, but maybe that's not a problem… seeing how I've been… defeating you *every* time since my arrival.

—You!

That did the trick.

Enraged, Shadow Weaver lost control, her magic tightened around Castaspella's legs, warm but not enough to burn, and began pulling from her. However, when she was almost over the edge of the mattress, the cold of her spell caused the dark sorceress to lose her balance and she fell to her knees. The woman had forgotten she had to stall the sheer cold; she always

neglected little details when blinded by rage, and Castaspella knew how to use that against her.

As she felt the dark magic had released her legs, she comfortably sat on the edge of the bed and looked down at Shadow Weaver, who was already expecting her smug expression when she looked up. She wanted to erase that smile from her face immediately, but she had lost, hadn't she? And at her own game no less.

—I think you know what follows now— Castaspella teased her.

—But you're already naked.

—Then you better put up a show for me, Dear.

The sorceress cast a few magical lights around them and looked at Shadow Weaver, expecting. The woman stared at her for a moment before she could finally stand up; new tendrils of black magic came out from under her dress but, this time, they only wrapped around herself, getting rid of her clothes.

—Enjoy it while you can, next time I won't let you win— she promised, naked now as she approached Castaspella.

—Sure, sure. You will have to if you want to be the one in charge— she mocked her. The sorceress didn't waste any time, her hands were already teasing her belly, tracing her scars up and down. —For now, I suppose you already know what I like.

—You better don't whine like a baby if your back hurts tomorrow— she warned her.

Castaspella instantly laughed and provoked —I should be the one saying that, old hag.

—You little- You asked for it, fool.

Complying, Shadow Weaver grabbed the sorceress' arms, pushed her against the nearest wall as she sardonically laughed, and pressed herself against Castaspella's back. The sorceress was still smirking, anticipating the bites on her back, and didn't hold back her moaning.

The dark sorceress could still see the old marks she had left on the woman the previous days and, along with her moaning, it was all more than enough to arouse her. Perhaps she preferred being the one giving out orders, but this wasn't that bad either.

The next morning, however, it was back to their public animosity, that could sometimes be very real; the women were discussing loudly enough to gather the attention of almost all soldiers on the base.

—…I do *not* follow your orders here.

—Alright then! Do as you please! Fail miserably again! You're *great* at that by now!— Castaspella retorted, knowing how much that would hurt.

Retribution.

—How dare you!— she roared loudly, immediately growing taller as her black magic surrounded them both. Shadow Weaver towered over the sorceress, yelling —Whatever makes you *think* a mere fool like *you* with no experience whatsoever in military training could *possibly* know more about this than me!? *I* have been training cadets for *decades*! I have even trained *sorcerers* for more years than you!

Everyone around them was scared half to death, most had even backtracked despite not being anywhere near them, and yet… Castaspella remained impassive, which only maddened Shadow Weaver all the more.

—As if you were doing a good job— she mocked her, rolling her eyes. —Listen to me, woman. Whatever you think you know must clearly be *very* wrong taking into account how things have gotten better since my arrival— she added, reminding the dark sorceress of that wicked smile she had seen on her that first night.

Before Shadow Weaver could reply, Hordak's voice interrupted. Everyone in the base saluted, immediately forgetting about the sorceresses' squabble.

Castaspella simply had to turn around, smile, and use that silver tongue of hers to walk away from this situation without consequences. On the contrary, for the dark sorceress, it would be far more difficult, even if she managed to swallow her pride and humble herself.

But she couldn't.

She just couldn't risk it.

—What is the *meaning* of this!?— Hordak demanded to know.

Trying and failing to hide her desperation, Shadow Weaver hastily replied —My Lord! This sorceress *cannot* be trusted! She insists I must be more lenient with my wards, she's *too nice* to the cadets! It's only natural to doubt her loyalty! I can and *will* get the truth out of her if you just allow me to…

—No— he interrupted her. —Speak, Castahex. What do you have to say?— he inquired, severe but far calmer than Shadow Weaver.

—I am, in fact, asking her to be more lenient; that much is true, Lord Hordak. However, it is only to ensure their best performance— she argued. At first, he seemed suspicious, but with that clarification, his expression totally changed. He looked pleased. —If we want the cadets to complete the new programs, they should be in *shape* to do so; forcing them to keep repeating the circuit just because they have failed the first dozen times only wears them out, and their performance decays.

—Correct as usual, Castahex— he agreed. —You should have listened to her when you could, Shadow Weaver. I will not tolerate more foolery from you! Especially if you only plan on undermining our most resourceful member right now.

—But, My lord…

—No buts! You should have come up with contributions of your own instead of repeatedly obstructing hers— he sentenced with severity. —I shall have a conversation with you, alone.

As everything fell silent, all soldiers resumed their activities, pretending nothing had happened. Castaspella, who had been holding her breath and focusing on keeping a straight face, finally looked back at Shadow Weaver. Even with the mask, she could notice the woman was terrified. But also, resigned. She tried to reach for her, but the sorceress dismissed her with a move of her hand and left, ready to face her punishment and be done with it quickly.

Castaspella was supposed to go on with her duties as normal, but this had been the first time she couldn't even interrupt to try and keep the woman safe from Hordak's rage. It would be too obvious there was something off as she had just accused her of treason, and she had no plausible explanation if she were asked why she defended her.

But she couldn't stop thinking about that fear of hers, as if she had seen a ghost. She supposed Hordak was going to punish her in some way, but *how* wasn't something she had ever wondered, as she had managed to keep that from happening during those days. What could possibly be so terribly to scare someone like *her* so much?

The sorceress followed silently and remained next to the entrance to Hordak's sanctum. There was no one around to see her, so she could stay by the door and watch.

—How many times…— Hordak began. —…Do I have to tell you…— he continued. —…To obey me?— he concluded, with a vicious tone. He pulled a lever and some sort of electricity crackled between a series of metallic poles around them, enclosing an area of the sanctum within a field of refractive energy. —We all serve a purpose, remember, Shadow Weaver? If you're my second in command, you're *supposed* to be reliable. But you aren't. Even if I demote you, what would be the point of keeping you here with no purpose?

—My Lord…

Shadow Weaver tried to speak, but began choking as the atmosphere around her became unbreathable. It was worse than drowning in water, the air felt heavy like lead, and with her mask on, it seemed like her head had been wrapped with thick fabric, suffocating her.

—We all serve a purpose, Shadow Weaver. If you don't fulfill your duties, you have to assist as my test subject. *Again*. You know how much is at stake, and everything I am doing to make sure I succeed. Don't ever dare *think* I would allow you to ruin it all.

Hordak finally turned around, walked back to the lever he had pulled, but didn't move it just yet. From the entrance, Castaspella could only watch in complete horror, covering her mouth with her hands to avoid screaming. Whatever that thing was, it made Shadow Weaver choke, scratch the floor in desperation, and utter sounds that might be failed screams.

And she just couldn't bear it.

Castaspella discreetly drew a spell and threw it at one of the metallic poles, making the whole field fail and go out before the dark sorceress passed out. She figured he'd never suppose it had been someone's meddling, as he had just said he was using her as a test subject.

She was right; he only growled, pulled the lever again to cut the energy, and walked to his workbench while yelling for her to get out. A small winged creature that Castaspella couldn't recognize came in flying, repeating Hordak's command a few times before settling on his shoulder. It observed as Shadow Weaver dragged herself out of the chamber, so the sorceress had to stay hidden.

The woman managed to stand up and slowly walk out, but her senses were so numb she couldn't even see or hear Castaspella when she grabbed her by the shoulders to take her to the Black Garnet chamber. The two of them finally reached the runestone and Castaspella had to help her stay on her feet and even hold her hands against the Garnet because Shadow Weaver was seconds away from completely collapsing.

The gem in her mask began glowing and electricity began accumulating within the runestone before finally flowing into the dark sorceress, tingling Castaspella's body as she held Shadow Weaver steady. She had suspected the mask would be needed for that and could barely resist the urge to remove it for her to breathe easier. Besides, if anyone happened to walk in, she wouldn't have any feasible explanation to give.

But it was even worse than that.

Perhaps he had it monitored because, moments after the gem began siphoning the runestone's energy, Hordak's image irrupted on the chamber, startling Castaspella, who latched onto Shadow Weaver tighter, instinctively wanting to protect her after what she had witnessed.

—What a surprise, Castahex. I wasn't expecting to see *you* helping the competition— he remarked, laying a careful trap.

But the sorceress caught up quickly, already used to days of Shadow Weaver's baiting, and seeing how both Hordak and Shadow Weaver would trick their underlings just like this.

Quick thinking, Castaspella. What would someone like Shadow Weaver be doing in her place?

—Ah, Lord Hordak. I must thank you for providing the perfect subject to test a little theory of mine— she began. This sounded extremely ironic but, as he had no idea she heard him before, it actually played to the sorceress' favor. —This runestone has some reinvigorating qualities which I've wanted to study in order to see if this can be used to keep the troops from wearing out so quickly on the battlefield; it would allow them to keep fighting even after the Rebellion's forces have exerted themselves— she elaborated. And now, to save their necks. —However, I had no way to study these interesting properties without the help of her unique ability to tap into runestone power. After returning in such a poor state, she had no choice but to help me, and I can even see for myself the effects— she lied, taking advantage of one of the things Shadow Weaver gloated so much about.

—I see…— he murmured. —And what has it…

—Ugh!

His question was suddenly interrupted by the dark sorceress' sudden groaning. She had now enough strength to push Castaspella away from her, but not enough to stand on her own yet, so she almost fell back to the ground. The sorceress barely managed to catch her before she hit the floor, and now had a new thing to explain.

—Well, well— she let out, buying herself time to craft something credible. —It seems like the effects aren't that effective or efficient. I'll probably have to run some more tests.

—So it appears— he agreed. —Report all your discoveries directly to me. And you have permission to do *everything* needed to get results. This could be the key to defeating the Rebellion once and for all.

—Yes, Lord Hordak.

His image finally disappeared and the chamber was once again illuminated solely by the faint light of the Garnet. An instant later, Shadow Weaver tried, once again, to push Castaspella away, but she was even weaker now.

—Easy there, Dear— she let out, smirking. —We're not done yet.

The sorceress managed to pull her up and, once again, pushed her hands against the Garnet. This time, the woman clawed at the runestone, so she withdrew her left hand, only to wrap it around Shadow Weaver's waist, keeping the woman pressed against herself. The tingling sensation of the Black Garnet's energy felt less invasive now, she might even enjoy it a little, she realized, and held her even tighter when she tried to break free again.

—You… treacherous… witch— Shadow Weaver groaned.

—Wait until you're more recovered to try and fight me, won't you?— Castaspella mocked her.

—Unhand me! Liar!

—Says the queen of deceivers!

—You- Ugh! I've never had someone believe I care… everyone knows I only use others— she insisted, her voice still strained.

—I disagree, but that's besides the point— the sorceress replied, in a lower tone, dropping the sarcasm now. —I need you to recover as much as possible so I can take you to the room. We can't talk here.

High up, in a tower overseeing all of Bright Moon, the Queen found her husband, looking into the distance with a somber demeanor. She hadn't seen him this depressed in years, and she knows exactly what is going on in his head. Pained, she approached him from behind and gently hugged him.

—We can still get her back, alright? It's only been a few days… I'm- I know she can be saved— she assured him. —And none of what happened is your fault, my Love. *This is not your fault*.

He let out a heavy sigh and replied —Don't you see? The past just came back to slap me in the face! It's- It's Light Spinner all over again! I *won't* get my sister back!

—We both know this is not the same— she reminded Micah, gently turning him around to face her.

As she brushed away his tears, he explained to her —Perhaps… in her case… she- she did obliterate someone, which Casta hasn't, but also… Light Spinner didn't hurt me. I- I really thought she would, but she only caressed my cheek. I- I don't know, perhaps she did care. And- and Casta… Just like she left before hurting me, my sister vanished before causing any damage at all because- because she loves and cares so much for her kingdom!

He kept sobbing, feeling heartbroken and powerless. Queen Angella couldn't bear seeing him in such a state, but she had done all she could for the moment. She hugged him tightly as he sobbed against her, finally allowing himself to let all the pain out.

After a few minutes, he finally calmed himself down and managed to breathe more easily. Angella slowly released him and cupped his face as she bent down to kiss his forehead.

—There's still hope, Micah— she whispered. —I know you can't take the role of Head Sorcerer, but at least you can try and… help the council manage things— she suggested. The Queen caressed his cheek lovingly before adding —We all know Casta loves her people, so you can go take care of Mystacor in her stead for now, my Love. Make sure she can return to the kingdom just as she left it.

Chapter End Notes

I promise you'll like where this is going, believe me.

Again, I'll be back ~~tomorrow~~ soon with the next part.

(And here I'll leave the eliminated scene, *enjoy*)

Always so short-sighted

Chapter Summary

Doubts quickly rise.

Loyalties and trust slowly dissolve into nothing.

And the sorceress remains a mystery, even to Shadow Weaver.

Chapter Notes

I am SO sorry, I had to update yesterday but
A) I've been rushing to finish writing this and couldn't focus enough yesterday
B) I was falling asleep while I tried to finish. I will NOT post low-quality content just to "post on time"; for schedules there's college already

Ahem, I hope you enjoy this chapter 😌👌

See the end of the chapter for more notes

—...I just can't trust you.

—You have trust issues.

—And you don't exactly make it easier.

Castaspella rested her head on Shadow Weaver's chest, feeling her claws tracing up and down the dark-pink scars on her arms. The woman noticed how they had barely crawled up a bit since she first arrived, and the only reason why they now looked much darker was entirely unrelated to her use of black magic.

How could she trust her if it was all so suspicious?

Yes, the woman was quite *wild*, so to say, in private, and *very* wicked in public. But Shadow Weaver had no way to know whether she had always been like this in private, and her "wickedness" was mere acting most times.

So who, just *who*, is this woman?

—Go along, won't you? I'm keeping you safe *and* alive, am I not?— Castaspella reminded her, smirking more softly than she should.

But the dark sorceress couldn't see that and, for her, it just sounded like her threatening offers, those manipulations Castaspella kept using with her. This has to be the same, something elaborated enough to be lasting this long, and "taking care of her" had to be just some means to achieve that.

—I won't just comply and let you use me— Shadow Weaver replied, severe but not angry. —I'd rather be killed by Hordak, or the corruption. Whatever happens first.

Castaspella's body tensed ever so slightly upon hearing that, but she shouldn't let the woman notice, and this was going nowhere, so she preferred to change subjects.

—What would happen to you if you couldn't get power from the Black Garnet?

—Why do you want to know?

Shadow Weaver's suspicions increased, but the sorceress was expecting that and already had an answer.

—I've been making sure Hordak doesn't take your privileges to use it, but hadn't asked before; this is quite dangerous for me, you could at the very least tell me why I'm risking my neck here.

She scoffed, indignant, recognizing that silver tongue of hers once again. But if that's how she will play, then Shadow Weaver wouldn't spare her the grim details.

—Agonizing death is what would happen— she began. —Using magic of *any* kind would drain my life-force until I'm nothing but a sack of bones— she went on, oblivious to Castaspella's look of horror. —"The corruption" is too general of a term to explain what actually happened that day; the kind of magic you and I learnt in Mystacor is nothing like the magic within the core of the planet, it's not a lesser form of magic but rather a power akin to those of the Princesses.

—But?— the sorceress asked, trying to hide her increasing worry.

—But I am *not* a Princess, I don't have any natural connection to this planet's magic, nor do I have any physical source of power like they do; using magic, sorcery or otherwise, drains what little magic my body has— she explained. —We all have a certain amount of magic flowing within us, just like blood does, but while sorcery gently guides outside's energy according to your will, what I got is the power to bend raw Etherian magic, in exchange for the one within me.

—So, the Garnet's magic…

—If I absorb that power, I can trick the corruption into using it instead of my life-force, and keep replenishing my own energy whenever my strength fails— Shadow Weaver interrupted. —In fact, it's just as you said: the Garnet has invigorating properties. Nothing that can be used as you told Hordak, but the fact that you realized…

—I'll take the compliment, but it wasn't that difficult to guess, you know?— Castaspella giggled.

—And yet you're the first person to ever realize as much.

The following days, Shadow Weaver little by little gave in and allowed the sorceress to manage Hordak's rage, took her advice, and not even once did it turn out to be a trap of any kind.

But it couldn't last long, and her mistrust returned faster than it had left.

—I'll make it clear— Hordak's voice roared. —Entrapta has now full access to the runestone, and you, Shadow Weaver, have no right to take it from her. If you attempt to do so, if you try to use it without her permission, there will be *consequences*.

Barely keeping her panic under control, the dark sorceress attempted to argue —But, my Lord…

—Excuse me, Lord Hordak— Castaspella's voice interrupted. She had stepped forward, getting between Shadow Weaver and the screen. —I have to request access to the Black Garnet too.

She didn't have to look back to know the woman was seething behind her, ready to react either angry or indignant, if not both, so she raised a finger, gesturing for her to keep quiet, making a show of displaying her "authority", knowing Hordak allowed it.

—Castahex— he hummed. —You've certainly won the right to it, and I'm *very* interested in your little project with it— he admitted. —But it will be Entrapta's decision.

That would be *easy*.

Castaspella turned left to where she comfortably sat on a bot while her hair held a large piece of technology on which she was working.

—Well, what do you say, Princess?— she asked with a tone that could be confused with cheerfulness.

—Huh… Sharing resources lowers the efficiency of my experiments, so it would be counterproductive— Entrapta considered. *Not the best moment for her to think like this*. — But, what do you need it for? I will use it for science!

That was close. The princess remained her usual self, so Castaspella was sure she could easily handle this.

—For experimentation too, of course— she replied with half a smile. —Perhaps I don't know about technology, but I certainly know about magic. I could easily provide assistance in that field if you need it, as compensation for the... reduced efficiency— she offered.

—Absolutely! I need accurate information about the magical properties of the runestone!— Entrapta immediately accepted.

It had been just as easy as Castaspella anticipated, and Shadow Weaver could hardly believe how well the sorceress had manipulated her. If she had never arrived, right now the woman would have unleashed her rage, and who-knows just how bad it would have gone.

—So it will be— Hordak sentenced, obviously pleased. —The Black Garnet is yours to use, Castahex, as long as you don't interfere with Entrapta's experimentation.

—Thank you, Lord Hordak. I'll make sure to be as unobtrusive as possible.

The moment the screen went out, Princess Entrapta jumped forward and immediately latched that piece she had just finished fixing, laughing happily when she saw the runestone react to it.

Castaspella, however, looked back at Shadow Weaver for a mere instant before leaving the chamber, silently thanking she hadn't made a scene. But she had clearly seen the way her black magic leaked from her, and it was better to leave now before the woman caught up.

She'd make such a scandal, it would be impossible to salvage unless she could drive Shadow Weaver to the most secluded corridor she could find. She had barely turned around the corner, hearing her quick footsteps echoing around, when darkness encased her for a moment before the dark sorceress materialized in front of her, pinning her against the cold metal wall.

—How dare you!?—. Her yelling resonated through the corridor, and Castaspella had to look to the side as Shadow Weaver's mask was a palm away from her face. —That runestone is mine!

—And you need it to live.

The sorceress' voice was calmer and lower, despite how violently she was being yelled at. Shadow Weaver drew back slightly, and let go of her wrists when Castaspella looked back, but the sorceress caught her hands instead and intertwined their fingers.

Her surprise lasted a second before she remembered and her claws dug into the sorceress'; it made her hiss but Castaspella held her sight. She wouldn't back down.

—Yet you betray me and take it for yourself!— Shadow Weaver reproached her. —First, you steal my place in the Horde, now my source of power! What game are you playing!?

—I already told you…

—Lies!

Shadow Weaver grew more enraged, but Castaspella couldn't help smirking; it was endearing and amusing.

—Always so short-sighted, Love— she began, sounding *soft*. But her tone changed to something more wicked as she explained —This is the only way for you to still have access

to it, idiot.

—Don't try to fool me.

—I am not, but you're too angry to see it— Castaspella insisted, rolling her eyes. She let out a dramatic sigh and mocked her —Good thing I stepped in or you would have doomed yourself with this reckless behaviour.

—What are you talking about!?— the dark sorceress barked.

—Had you complained and made this kind of fuss, Hordak would have demoted you immediately and I'd have no way to help you— she pointed out. —But, because I know you need that power to stay alive, I couldn't just stop you. I *needed* to make sure you can get it when you need it...

—You mean...

Castaspella smirked smugly as she sentenced —Now I can use any excuse to let you get power from it.

Shadow Weaver finally calmed down, loosened her grip and withdrew her black magic; she was stunned, and impressed, perhaps even jealous.

—I can hardly believe you're wicked enough to come up with such a plan.

The sorceress laughed daintily, taking advantage of her shock to release her hands, finally leaving the wall, and walked down the corridor, knowing the woman would follow her.

—I now have no reasons to obey blindly and follow whatever I'm told to do. Just like you, I can and will use all my resources to get my way— she casually let out. —Don't you like being such a successful teacher?

She was good. She had to give it to her.

Shadow Weaver finally snapped out of her shock, began walking after her, and scoffed —Shut up before I regret all of this.

The sorceresses reached an empty storage room and Castaspella pulled her in. They wouldn’t be found for a while, and being pinned to the wall had made her thirsty, just like understanding the full mastery of her plan had aroused Shadow Weaver.

As days went by, the problems in the Horde increased. Castaspella had arrived more than a week ago now and, even when she had helped so much, it didn’t seem like any *real* improvements had been made in terms of results.

The soldiers and scouts were better equipped, but they would usually be found and even ambushed by the Rebellion as they seemed to be expecting them, knowing their objectives;

suspicions of a mole immediately raised, everyone was on edge. And then the sabotage began: if trust was already an issue, then it now turned into a huge danger.

With no clues about who it could possibly be, the only suspects were the lowest ranks or those who kept failing their tasks, seemingly the more likely to undermine the Horde.

Until a Rebellion's strategist was *captured*.

It had been the first significant progress in days; the soldiers dragged the tired man in front of Hordak and kicked him to the ground. He was already bleeding, apparently had difficulty breathing, and no spare strength to resist. But the soldiers were angry enough to just use him as punching-bag.

To the kick followed a shock batton, a few more kicks, and a very wicked round of electro-shocks. They weren't trying to extract information from him or anything, just wanted to make him suffer, release all the stress after a week of failure.

Castaspella couldn't bear watching for long; no amount of unscrupulousness would ever let her just sit and watch someone being tortured.

—That's enough!— she sentenced, walking forward.

The sorceress immediately called everyone's attention, just as she expected, yet didn't hesitate as she approached the wounded Rebel and shooed away the soldiers that where torturing him.

—Explain yourself, Castahex— Hordak immediately order, displeased with her meddling.

—I beg your pardon, Lord Hordak, but your soldiers caught a rebellion *strategist*, and their only idea was to beat him up? What a waste— she began, with a side glance to the beaten guy. Her stare gave him chills and, suddenly, he wished the brute soldiers had killed him. —I must insist we interrogate him, it would be far more productive; he's bound to have useful information.

Castaspella's words convinced him once again, commenting on productiveness always does, but he seemed suspicious still, as he decided to make a test of sorts for her.

—So be it, then— he accepted. —*You* will interrogate him, and *no one* is allowed to interfere in any way— he ordered. It became evident this was a test when he concluded —Let's see how effective your interrogations are.

She towered over the rebellion strategist, who had been sat in front of a small table and remained tightly tied. The room was almost empty save for that, sick yellowish lights buzzed monotonously and made Castaspella look monstrous with her scars, yet the prisoner was brave enough to talk back at her despite how scary she looked.

—Yo-you- How *could* you!? You-you *betrayed* us! You were- you were the-the Head Sorceress! You had to- had to protect… your people! *Our* people!— he stammered, shaking a

bit.

She had to make a huge conscious effort to remain serious and expressionless, sat in front of him, and let out a long sigh.

—I do not want to harm you. I just want some information— she began, talking calmly but severely. —Give me something and I will make sure you're only kept prisoner and *never* disposed of.

He stared for a moment, confused and fearful, before indignation overtook him and he retorted —I don't… understand. You want me to trust you!? What part of "you're a traitor" did you not hear!? Or-or was that supposed to be a threat!?

Castaspella closed her eyes for a moment, taking a deep breath, and tried again —I am not threatening you. First of: you most probably know already that, once you're out of this room, you'll either go to a cell or to a transport headed for Beast Island. Which one it is will depend on whether you give me something or not.

Despite how threatening it sounded, he ignored the chills that gave him and barked —I have nothing to give you!

—You do— she insisted, calmly. —Whatever strategy plans you can remember will do.

—I will *not* betray my squad or put our soldiers in danger just to save my skin!

—You wouldn't— the sorceress assured him. Stunned, he stared as she reminded him —You and I know the most common damage-control strategies Queen Angella implements: when someone of your rank or higher is captured, all strategies are changed immediately. *Precisely* in case this happens.

—Why would you- I don't understand!— he exclaimed, bewildered. —Why are you asking me for this information that you *know* is useless!?

Castaspella looked him dead in the eye as she replied —Because *they* don't know that.

—That's… Ah…

The rebellion strategist took a deep breath, feeling calmer now, and finally gave in.

By the time the sorceress opened the door and called for some guards to take the man to a holding cell, Shadow Weaver was already standing in front of the door, expecting. She saw as he was being taken away, how he spared a glance at Castaspella, but only showing resignation.

Suspicious again, she followed her to hear what she would report, and kept quiet since arriving in front of Hordak.

—I see you've sent the prisoner to a holding cell. What information has he given you?

—With his rank, he has access to all current strategies and may even be involved in their crafting himself— Castaspella explained first. —I got a detailed list of strategies the Rebellion plans to use next.

Hordak looked extremely pleased as he replied —Sounds useful indeed. This was a good decision on your part, Castahex, but we should now dispose of him if this is all we'll get.

—In fact…— the sorceress interrupted. —That would be very unwise, seeing how the rebellion can *still* change strategies. However, if we take the information the scouts gathered, we can have him guess what strategy the rebellion is trying to build, allowing us more reaction time to any possible changes.

Hordak narrowed his eyes, pensive for a moment, but finally admitted —Yes. Quite clever of you. We shall keep the rebellion prisoner for as long as needed, until we finally *crush* them all.

For hours, Shadow Weaver neglected her duties, all too interested in figuring out Castaspella's game, until she couldn't take it anymore and went to find her. She knew this was the time of the day when the sorceress would go and take a shower, being the only time when no one else used the baths, and perhaps it would play to her favor.

Castaspella anticipated her arrival and held back a laugh, knowing it would be easy to distract her, but pretended she hadn't noticed her enter the room.

When Shadow Weaver was about to "catch her by surprise", Castaspella laughed —*Someone* has to work on her stealth.

—Bitch— she muttered. —What gave me away?

—Lucky you, nothing. I just recognized your… magic— the sorceress replied, laying the trap.

—Is that so? And how *exactly* does that work?— she asked, stepping closer already.

She had her.

Castaspella turned around, purposely leaned out of the shower, and invited —Come and find out.

She managed to distract Shadow Weaver for a few minutes, but the woman hadn't forgotten and could easily play the same game. She approached Castaspella from behind, grabbed both sides of her torso, and pulled her close.

The sorceress shivered as the woman whispered in her ear —Will you tell me now how that interrogation went? And I don't mean the *results*, I mean how you handled the *process*.

—I don't see why I should— she teased her, leaning back against her.

—Because it is highly suspicious how the man didn't look scared or troubled after the interrogation, and absolutely did *not* fear you—. Shadow Weaver clutched Castaspella's torso without breaking the skin with her claws, and pressed on —It makes one think that you're just pretending to have changed sides, and now try to keep him alive. *You've exposed yourself*.

The sorceress immediately held Shadow Weaver's hands in place and leaned back once again, looking up at her with a smirk as she asked —Did I?

—Did you…— she let out, shocked. —Did you… make *him* think you're betraying the Horde so that he would *trust you*!?

—Perhaps…

Her tone and the eye roll turned on the dark sorceress, who held her tighter as she replied —How very wicked of you—. Right after, she briefly dug her fangs into Castaspella's neck before adding —But don't think you can possibly surpass me there.

—Is that a challenge?— the sorceress hummed.

—Take it as you please.

The woman turned around between Shadow Weaver's arms and whispered —I absolutely will.

The sorceresses were under cold water already, but remained under the shower, harshly kissing, touching their bodies hungrily, and trying to push each other against the wall.

Castaspella had, once again, distracted her.

Two days later, Shadow Weaver woke up in the middle of the night, her head resting on the sorceress' chest, feeling extremely tired. She felt so numb she simply remained there, staring at the naked body under her; pink scars had barely crawled up her forearm, they still looked reversible enough, and it took her a moment too long to realize *why* it irked her so much.

Of course.

Why would Castaspella suddenly be all wicked and evil, if she herself hadn't lost her will after the corruption? She had joined the Horde because she wanted revenge on those fools who had doubted, rejected, and betrayed her.

What could have happened to the Head Sorceress then?

She still didn't know why she had "gone crazy", perhaps it was time to finally ask her. She'd wait until Castaspella awakened, and wouldn't let her go until she had answered everything.

She still couldn't trust her.

—Casta?— Shadow Weaver called, when she felt her stir beneath her. The sorceress hummed in response, so she continued —What exactly happened to you? How were you… corrupted?

Castaspella opened one eye, curious, and quickly realized why she was asking. She moved her hands up and started to caress the long silky black hair of the dark sorceress, while speaking with a tone both sensual and sardonic.

—Well… remember that little dark imp you sent to try and mess with the ritual during the eclipse? It tried to reach the lunar lenses through me, but of course I wouldn't let it; that much you know already, am I right?—. Shadow Weaver nodded, unwillingly enjoying how the woman caressed her hair, and let her continue —What you don't know, I guess, is that restraining your imp within me cut its connection to you and connected it to me instead. Your… "umbrakinesis" is the appropriate name, right? Well, that visibly corrupted me, everyone saw as much.

—I'm sure it was nothing like my corruption…

—I wouldn't know— she laughed. —But the acolytes got so scared they immediately ran away! I preferred to teleport away before anyone returned— she concluded. Almost immediately, she remembered something and, with a mocking tone, added —Oh, but I had no need to be so *petty* and obliterate anyone. That was very low from you, Dear.

Shadow Weaver scoffed and teased her, moving her hands up and licking her chest, insulting Castaspella under her breath, which only made the sorceress laugh. She wanted to believe her, but still felt like she couldn't. Everything was so convenient, and she had proven to be a masterful manipulator being now devoid of scruples.

It had become difficult to know what was true and what wasn't with this woman, Shadow Weaver felt like she had become an irresistible poison, she'd be her demise and couldn't be trusted, but she couldn't help wanting more of her.

It was late at night already when the Princess Alliance held an emergency meeting. Queen Angella preceded, as always, and looked extremely serious.

—We have received a new message from *our source*— she began. —The strategist the Horde captured is being held in a prison cell and remains out of danger for now— she explained, checking the message a few times. —But this isn't all. This person urges us to prepare a full raid on the Horde to be deployed soon— the Queen added. —They insist this is our only chance to do this. However, despite not having been lied to by this person, we still don't know who they are, so we can't blindly take their advice— she elaborated. Finally, her demeanor changed to something even more severe as she declared —Today, we shall decide whether we prepare this raid or not.

Chapter End Notes

Well well, that's all for today!
I'll try to post the next chapter tomorrow, otherwise, the day after 😅 I hope.

And here, I'll leave the eliminated scene. 😏 if you've known the previous ones, then you know what to expect.

The end of it all

Chapter Summary

Life in the Fright Zone goes on.
An attack is prepared.
And the sorceress learns what it means to belong to the Horde.

»He extended a hand down for her to take and helped her up; once she was on her feet, her face frozen in stupor, he brushed away the tear still wetting the side of her eye and let out —You have now been purified and are worthy of the Horde.

So the end approaches.
It's time for the final confrontation.
And only one party can prevail.

Chapter Notes

You have no idea just how long this chapter is
Gods, I went overboard but I'm so happy I finally finished it!!!!

Now:
Clarification:
I don't think Hordak is *the* wicked one (everyone here is wicked), nor am I trying to villainize him or make him "worse than SW", but rather keep him as in-character as possible with the imposed mindset from his life before arriving to Etheria, with this belief that flaws, impurities, mistakes, should be punished or purged, as Prime would do to the clones. Aka, he doesn't know any better and I HAVE to keep that here, I have to represent the religious-trauma-coded characteristics shown in the series. So if you're reading this and are a Hordak fan/stan, apologies if you find the characterization offending or something, especially in this chapter. I'm not trying to throw hate on him or on spacebat fans; nothing of the like

With that said, I hope you enjoy the chapter and do mind the tw for torture.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

—I believe you have received my report, Lord Hordak— Castaspella began.

He sat on his throne, looking down at her and Shadow Weaver.

—I did, yes. Good to know this prisoner is, in fact, quite useful— he replied. —So the forces they are gathering are just to defend the Whispering Woods…— he let out, thinking aloud. —Quite a waste of resources. We'll have a chance to attack all their unprotected outposts once they have settled the troops— he decided. Then, he glared at Shadow Weaver —Well? Any progress? Or are you *still* wasting time and resources like the Rebellion?

The dark sorceress cleared her throat, mustering all her strength to keep herself from lashing out.

—I have been investigating the sabotages. Most leads would suggest it's low-ranking recruits' doing.

—But you haven't caught a single culprit yet…

Because she has been trying to spy on Castaspella to no avail…

But she can't say that.

—I am keeping an eye on some… *potential* culprits; we need proper evidence. If we accuse someone who isn't the saboteur, we might alert them and they will escape before we can catch them.

Hordak glared at her, trying to figure out the scam, but soon realized that, even if it were a lie, she's right and it's quite likely to happen.

—So you *can* be worthwhile after all— he replied, pensive. As he was looking away, he never noticed Shadow Weaver squinting at him, and when he looked back, she immediately composed herself before he continued —In that case, maintain your *wise* decision and make sure to gather enough proof. Then, bring everything to *me* and I shall *purify* them.

With a respectful bow, she uttered —Of course, Lord Hordak.

Of course, she already planned to keep an eye on her *one* suspect: Castaspella.

Dutifully true to her word, she spent the whole day following the sorceress around, trying to catch her wrecking something or stealing some key component of a machine, perhaps even visiting the prisoners to plan something.

But she did nothing of the like.

Castaspella was only fulfilling her job and nothing more. She sent a few scout squads to gather information, supervised the trainees' tests, filled out paperwork, and assisted Entrapta with her experiments.

Perhaps she wasn't doing anything after all.

Maybe Shadow Weaver was simply being petty because the woman could outsmart her, and potentially outrank her if things continued that way.

And yet…

One night, when her three young cadets returned from a mission, she overheard Kyle panicking about it being ruined by the rebels who seemed to be waiting for them and kept all their equipment when they were forced to retreat.

It was yet another sabotage most likely, so Shadow Weaver stuck around to eavesdrop. And so, she eventually realized Castaspella was there too.

—Bu-but… Enchantress! We-we lost everything! A-all the gear! The weapons! The-the tech for Entrapta! A-and Adora and Catra were the ones who ambushed us! We-we can't- We…

—Kyle, calm down— Castaspella interrupted him. —Do you *know* the definition of an ambush?— she asked, sternly. —None of you could have predicted it… and, apparently, your former mates are… quite the strategists— she continued. —Now: Lord Hordak called you to the throne, presumably to… punish you. So *I*, as the one responsible for your mission, *will* go with you.

—But…

—No more buts!

—Kyle, just let her!— Lonnie insisted, seconded by a roar from Rogelio. —It's not like Shadow Weaver *ever* took responsibility for us. Just *once*, think!

—But-

—Stop with that already!— she interrupted him, before Castaspella could do it again. With a grunt, she gave up on convincing him and turned towards the sorceress to ask —Please, Enchantress. We… would a-appreciate it if you don't leave us alone for this.

—I will not— she immediately replied. —As I said, this was my responsibility. Besides, I was *not* asking for your permission.

Shadow Weaver heard her footsteps as the woman left the room, soon followed by her wards, and carefully sneaked behind them, wanting to know what Hordak would do.

—Lord Hordak— Castaspella saluted, bowing respectfully before him, and standing between him and the cadets, as if trying to keep him from seeing them at all.

—Castahex— he noticed, sounding somewhat surprised. —Quite *thoughtful* of you to bring them here yourself, but it was *unnecessary*.

—Excuse me, my Lord, but that isn't the reason why I came— she replied, tilting her head forward to humble herself. —I am here to request that these cadets be exempt from any punishments you may have in mind and allowed to return to their quarters now.

—And what exactly makes you think I would *ever* agree to do such a thing?— he asked, frowning and squinting at her, suddenly suspicious. —Do not expect me to show them *mercy* solely because of your merits.

—May I remind you, Lord Hordak, that this squad was following *my* orders? In any case, *I am to blame* for their failure.

Behind her, the cadets exchanged surprised glances, unable to believe what she was saying, and Hordak was just as surprised, although making a huge effort to hide it.

He hummed and let out —Indeed. I see you know your place here, Castahex—. Right after, he glared at Shadow Weaver's hiding spot and added —Unlike *others*—. Once again, he had managed to discover her spying and called her out, making everyone look towards her. Without paying attention to her anymore, he addressed Castaspella again, ordering —In that case, step forward.

—Yes, Lord Hordak— she complied, shivering imperceptibly and cursing the fact that the cadets hadn't been dismissed.

They would *see it all*.

—Let this be an example of proper respect for authority— he sentenced, leaning back on his throne.

A pair of armed guards that were standing at the door approached Castaspella the moment Hordak gestured at them. The both of them took out their batons and turned on the electro-shocking feature right before touching both sides of the sorceress with a mild voltage.

Her pained shrieks, even if anticipated by everyone, sounded worse than imagined, to the point even Hordak himself seemed uncomfortable. But he couldn't stop this: she had to be purified, punished for her mistakes, and made worthy of belonging to the Horde, right?

It had to go on.

Castaspella knew that, as she was taking responsibility for *three* cadets, it wasn't nearly done yet, but she wasn't going to back down now.

—Go on— she requested, serious, almost defying.

Once again, the guards electrocuted her, for a bit longer this time, and her head jerked back as she let out a piercing scream, before falling forward and needing to support herself with both hands, unable to lift her torso.

It was unbearable, but she wouldn't let herself give up and, after shamelessly letting out a wicked laugh, she yelled —Go ahead with the last one!

Reluctantly, the guards raised the voltage and hit her back with the tip of their batons. This time, she couldn't even look up, kept her head down, her eyes tightly shut, and wailed agonizingly until it ended. Depleted of strength, she fell on her left side, staring at the distance, and a single tear slowly fell down the side of her left eye.

Before returning to their positions, one of the guards whispered —We're sorry.

—That should be enough— Hordak sentenced. —All of you have to learn: only the flawless can be admitted into Prime's glory. And through suffering will you be rid of imperfections— he added, with a proud tone, as he descended from the throne and approached Castaspella. He could recall how Prime would always receive them back into the light, and now, he had to do the same. He extended a hand down for her to take and helped her up; once she was on her feet, her face frozen in stupor, he brushed away the tear still wetting the side of her eye and let out —You have now been purified and are worthy of the Horde.

So that was what being part of the Horde meant…

Pushing through the lump in her throat, she stammered —Tha-thank you, Lord Hordak.

Hours later, when she was done with her duties of the day, Shadow Weaver returned to her room, only to find Castaspella resting there, looking at the roof, seemingly catatonic.

—Casta?

With a certain lethargy, the sorceress moved her head barely enough to look at her standing at the door but said nothing. Seeing her in such a state, the dark sorceress decided against confronting her right then as planned and only entered the room in silence.

After taking off the first layers of clothes, Shadow Weaver went to lay down next to Castaspella and could only briefly close her eyes before the sorceress broke the silence.

—What is it?

—You seemed… unwell— she hesitantly replied.

—Worried about me?

—Have you forgotten that *torture* from earlier?

—It was nothing— Castaspella replied. —At least I didn't almost collapse like you…

—I am *trying* not to-

—What I mean…— the sorceress interrupted, turning her head to look at Shadow Weaver. —...Is that yours was *worse*.

—Right…

—I mean it. I'm fine. Just… a bit sore.

—Then you wouldn't mind if I asked you *why* all the sabotaging points at you, would you?

Castaspella immediately smirked and made an effort to push herself up and turn towards the dark sorceress.

—What if I do mind?

—You make yourself even more suspicious.

—Is that what you think?

—Why else would I be asking?

Teasingly, Castaspella put a finger on the base of Shadow Weaver's neck and brushed it down between her breasts while saying —Perhaps because every time you do… it only leads to our particular kind of *fun*.

—I am not looking for that. I just want you to explain yourself.

The sorceress grunted as she struggled to push herself further up yet, soon enough, she was sitting on top of Shadow Weaver, hiding her pain behind a sly smirk.

—Are you sure? Would you miss this opportunity? I'm in no shape to claim the top position this time…

—Casta…

Leaning over her, she moved her face closer and whispered —Won't you treat me *well* if you're so worried about me?

—I never said that— the dark sorceress instantly corrected. —But…

Finding her too tempting, Shadow Weaver smirked and gave in, immediately making Castaspella gasp.

The next morning, by the time the sorceress woke up, the woman beside her was already wide awake.

—Morning— she mumbled, still sleepy.

—Morning…

Castaspella yawned and turned towards her, snuggling closer, and Shadow Weaver almost immediately held her tightly. It made the sorceress suddenly wary as she had never been held by her that way.

—Is everything alright?

—No. You never answered me— the dark sorceress reminded her. —When I left and joined the Horde, my morals remained the same, and what I do is only because I was *betrayed* by

that council; I lost all respect for them, those fools rejected me and *this* is my revenge because the best way to achieve it was joining their enemy… But you? The corruption wouldn't change your morals, that much I know, so why the change of heart? I am *not* letting go of you until you tell me what reasons you have for this.

So she was right to be alert.

However, soon enough Castaspella's wariness dissolved and she simply made herself comfortable between her arms, grinning calmly and closing her eyes.

—Then I suppose we're *not* leaving the bed today…

—If you have no reasons… then you *must* be the traitor.

—Is that so?— the sorceress asked, smirking and keeping her eyes closed. —If that were the case… what would you do?— she continued, her tone slightly malicious. Keeping her voice low, she looked up at Shadow Weaver and reminded her —Take into account that Hordak considers me to be better than you while, well, you're merely *useful*. He'd believe you're only trying to get rid of the competition before I can take your place…

The dark sorceress scoffed bitterly and asked —Why are you *so* hellbent on trying to prove you can be more wicked than me?

Castaspella only smirked and snickered as she snuggled closer, reinforcing her decision of not answering Shadow Weaver's question, which left the woman thinking, trying once again to decipher the sorceress.

—Tell me… If you could prove to him that I'm a traitor and that it's not a tactic of yours to get rid of me because I threaten your place here… would you be willing to sit and watch as I'm punished again and, probably, disposed of?— she asked her, serious enough to worry Shadow Weaver. —I mean… you seem to *enjoy me* quite much— she then added, finally using a lighter tone.

Noticeably relieved, the dark sorceress tried to brush it off, much to Castaspella's amusement.

—Mere lust. You know that perfectly well.

—Really? Then why have you questioned me privately instead of, for instance, publicly exposing me? At least, even if you couldn't prove it, you'd still cast a shadow of doubt on me, no?

—I…

She couldn't reply.

This was another question she had refused to observe or answer to herself. And once more, Castaspella's teasing touch on her chest distracted her from these thoughts and her suspicions, her weariness of the sorceress.

—Go ahead, don't be ashamed… You feel something for me, don't you?

Her snicker right after only weakened Shadow Weaver's resolve and tempted her to give in. However, she only grabbed the hand teasingly brushing her chest and held it while struggling to hide her hesitation behind a serious tone.

—What would you do if I said I do?

A smirk gradually appeared on Castaspella's lips before she casually replied —If, hypothetically, you liked me, and I, hypothetically, were the traitor, then I'd make sure you can escape with me when this place falls. How would you like that?

The sorceress' hand held hers back and Shadow Weaver felt frozen in place. She didn't notice how Castaspella was moving her face closer to her neck until she felt a tender kiss right before a teasing bite.

She had obviously learnt what the dark sorceress liked, and now, she indiscriminately used it against her.

After a few minutes of kissing and biting, Shadow Weaver eventually forgot about the question and they both got up to start the day.

The next few days, Shadow Weaver continues to spy on her but, now, there's a certain hesitation, and sometimes, she would even stop herself, as if fearing she'd discover real proof.

The sorceress was *right*.

There's… a feeling, one she doesn't like but, clearly, it's there.

Why did she have to show up!?

Shadow Weaver certainly didn't need this…

But it happened, and it gave her the sudden urge to confront her about these feelings instead of merely about the sabotage.

—What are you doing to me?— she asked the sorceress, following her as she walked down an empty hall. She had been waiting to catch her as soon as she left the bathrooms, knowing the woman would lure her into a trap once again if she went inside to confront her. —How have you- Did you curse me? The corruption marks in your body have barely increased. Did you use that magic to hypnotize me in some way?

—You flatter me, but I believe you know charming spells don't work that way…

The sorceress went on, heading for a concurred area, knowing it would force Shadow Weaver to take her into a more secluded room to continue their chat, which would give her *the* opportunity she needed.

—You know what I'm talking about. *Hypnosis*, making me believe things that aren't my ideas!

—Is this about your… hypothetical feelings?

Castaspella smirked as she continued to walk, hearing the soldier's footsteps louder now. However, the dark sorceress only followed her, and they neared the last room before the end of the corridor.

—Don't try to fool me…— she exclaimed, tearing off her mask and revealing her enraged demeanor. —I won't let you digress again!

—Oh, Dear— she let out, and turned around with a smug expression, hiding her annoyance. —You're giving me too much credit— she whispered, nearing Shadow Weaver's face until their lips brushed.

Immediately, the woman grabbed her by the arm, dragged her into the room to her left, and slammed the door behind them.

Success.

—What part of keeping things secret have you forgotten!?

—None.

—You… did it on purpose!?

—Precisely— she admitted with a smirk, and took a step forward. —I wanted some privacy…

Right as she said it, her hands found Shadow Weaver's waist and slowly brushed towards her back. The dark sorceress quickly picked up on her intentions, yet it wasn't Castaspella's full plan…

—I see. But if this is what you wanted, you just had to request it…

—You didn't seem to be in the mood…

—So you preferred to force my hand— Shadow Weaver interrupted. —Was it because I *was* asking you something? You better answer it now.

The sorceress had been trapped against a wall, their faces a breath away, yet Castaspella refused to give in.

—I'm sorry to disappoint, but I've done nothing magical to you… I just *seduced* you, didn't I? You wanted me, that's why this all started; I had no need to do anything other than offer a chance, which you took…

—A chance to drink the worst poison…

—Is that what “love” is called in your language?— she interrupted and let out a snicker. —Is my *poison* invading your system? Running through your veins?— she asked, her tone low once again.

—I can’t- I shouldn’t- I *mustn’t* trust you!

Castaspella reached up for her chin with a hand and let out —I’m flattered by your hesitation…

—Stop deflecting…

—I already answered your question— the sorceress immediately replied, once again letting her hands roam Shadow Weaver’s body. —Can’t you relax a bit now?

—Why are you doing this?— Shadow Weaver insisted.

The way she put it made the dark sorceress hesitant as she realized she had, in fact, no idea what Castaspella actually planned. She *thought* she knew it, but now it was obvious to her that the sorceress wasn’t just seducing her to avoid the subject; there had to be an ulterior motive.

—Is that not clear?

Shadow Weaver only froze under her touch, first gentle then suddenly rougher; she really wanted it, and so did the dark sorceress, but she could hardly shake her suspicions.

Hesitantly leaning forward, and holding back a pleased gasp, she whispered —Why now?

—I feel like it… But if you don’t…

—I do.

—Yet you don’t trust me. Is that the problem?

—I can’t…

—Why?

—You’re just trying to lead me away from something. You always do that…

—Would it help if… I let you lead? Or, well, give you some control at least— she offered, letting out a snicker before meeting her lips.

And there it was again.

The need. The *desire*.

She couldn’t help it and kissed her back immediately, letting her hands wander Castaspella’s body too, quickly giving in to temptation. Soon enough, her hands had reached the sorceress’

chest, teased the rim of her dress, and her lips moved down her jaw and neck towards her collarbone.

On the other hand, Castaspella's hands gripped Shadow Weaver's waist and pushed her back until she hit a dusty table. Immediately, the dark sorceress turned around and lifted her to have her sit on the table instead as she continued to kiss her hungrily.

They were at it for almost an hour when they got interrupted by loud alarms blaring through the Fright Zone; all lights went out save for a few emergency ones installed in all rooms. The sorceresses could hear frantic footsteps outside and, after a moment of shock, Shadow Weaver raised her head to face Castaspella, who didn't seem the littlest bit surprised.

As the sounds of attacks in the background put the dark sorceress on edge, she quickly fixed her clothes while taking a few steps back, leaving her on the table.

—It's… An attack!? How can you be this calm!?

—We're safe here, are we not?

Castaspella's aloof behaviour as she calmly put her dress back in place worsened Shadow Weaver's panic but she refused to show it and immediately left the room. Cursing under her breath, the sorceress jumped off the table, rushed behind her while shaking the dust from her cape, and quickly found her at the Black Garnet chamber.

—How? All the defense systems are down!

Shadow Weaver was leaning over her basin, focused on the images her shadow spies showed her: rebellion soldiers storming into quarters, doors jammed, and Entrapta's modified bots breaking down as their rusty joints gave in, or shortcircuited, or suddenly found themselves depleted of energy.

—You should have stayed in the room…

Upon hearing the sorceress behind her, Shadow Weaver turned around and her powers immediately surrounded her in darkness. The next moment, the dark sorceress was, once again, a breath away from Castaspella, but with her mask in place this time.

—Is this what you used the black magic for!?

—What a sharp observation…

The tone, so similar to her own, fed Shadow Weaver's rage; it was *maddening*.

—You don't care about the Horde in the slightest!

—Neither do you. But, at this point, I care *a lot* about you— the sorceress retorted.

—So what? You'll just let it all burn down around us!— she accused her. —You just… want us to drown in this *shameful* relationship of ours… Don't you!? Nothing else matters to you! Only us!— she exclaimed, more as if she were thinking aloud as realization hit. —Is that it!?

Castaspella was smirking even before she finished talking.

Close enough, but *not quite there*.

—Oh, Dear. You almost guessed it. But you are, in fact, *wrong*…

Shocked, the dark sorceress could only let out —What!?

—I still care for my brother, and his family, the Rebellion, and Etheria— she began. —You're just now *at the top of my list*.

After a moment of hesitation, staring at her in utter bewilderment, she finally realized —You *are* the traitor.

—I learnt from the best— Castaspella whispered, looking defiantly into the white sockets of the mask.

Shadow Weaver finally receded and returned to the basin; Castaspella approached from behind and looked over her shoulder as the spies showed the Horde in shambles.

—How… did you do it?

—The captured strategist confirmed the Rebellion was preparing a full raid, not a defense line… So I changed the report— she admitted, with an amused tone.

—The report…

The dark sorceress turned to face her once again. Right after, a shadow spy arrived with a batch of papers which she immediately snatched; with a quick spell, she revealed the original report, the *real* report, confirming what Castaspella had said.

—Who wrote the original one?

—The strategist, of course— she replied, trying to look at the basin once again as something called her attention. —Well, look at that…

—Hordak already escaped…

He seemed furious, occasionally looked over his shoulder, and ran even faster until the soldiers stopped following him; staying hidden behind a tall building, he slammed his fist against the wall, denting it with the strength of the hit. His hand then reached for the piece of First Ones' tech under his neck before, once again, frowning angrily.

—But he thinks Entrapta betrayed her— Castaspella guessed. —Can you show her?— the sorceress requested. Shadow Weaver nodded and made a gesture, changing the images in front of them to the princess. —Oh, they got her…

Princess Entrapta had been restrained by the hands and was being held prisoner along with Scorpia, while a couple of princesses, Perfuma, Mermista, and Spinnerella, tried to talk to them, perhaps to convince them to surrender. But the Scorpioni princess kept trying to free her pincers, and put herself between Entrapta and the others, protectively.

—What about…— Shadow Weaver muttered, gesturing again. —Ah, there they are… I should have guessed my wards wouldn't fight.

The Horde Trio was running away from a squad of Rebellion soldiers, who kept closing in on them. Before they could see more, Castaspella tapped the dark sorceress on the shoulder to call her attention and extended a hand towards her, smirking.

—Come with me?

Knowing she didn't have more options, the woman closed her eyes and sighed —Fine…

The sorceress teleported them both near where they had seen Shadow Weaver's wards and, with a little movement of her hand, Castaspella cast a sigil that hindered the rebellion soldier's movement, making them trip over to allow the Horde Trio to escape.

—There we go… They are just kids, they have done nothing other than follow orders.

The dark sorceress looked back at her, questioningly, but before she could ask anything, a voice called their attention.

—A-auntie!?

Without hesitation, Castaspella immediately ran to hug Glimmer, laughing happily, as if they weren't right in the middle of a battlefield. On the contrary, Glimmer looked conflicted and reticent. She could barely process what was happening as she had mentally readied herself to fight her own aunt.

But instead, the sorceress had greeted her like she'd do whenever she visited Mystacor.

—Oh, I'm so glad to see you safe!

—No, no, no— Glimmer let out, shaking her head and taking a few steps back. —You- I- You're lucky mom hasn't seen you yet— she hesitantly warned her. —How- Why!? How could you do this to us!?

Surprised, Castaspella opened her eyes wide and admitted —Well, I know what to expect from your mother and I can handle her—. She then gestured dismissively and added —And it's far more complicated than you think, Dear.

Glimmer was ready to ask what she meant when they heard a loud yell that caught their attention and looked right in time to see Angella charging at them, flying at full speed, ready to fire.

Before she could hit Castaspella, the sorceress raised a shield, instinctively using black magic as she feared her sorcery wouldn't be enough. However, Shadow Weaver immediately saw

the marks of corruption extending down her cheeks and promptly grabbed her by the arm to stop her.

Raising a shield of her own after shaking her by the arms to dispel Castaspella's, she yelled —What are you doing!? You will make the corruption irreversible!

—You little traitor!— Angella accused her, as soon as she landed, spreading her wings to cover Glimmer behind them. —How dared you!? How could you do this to us!? Do you know how much you've hurt your brother!? Do you have any *idea* how much he has cried for you!?

As her hands still glowed, ready to attack, Shadow Weaver kept her shield up and interrupted before Castaspella could reply.

—She was the spy, don't you see!? She fooled us all!— she explained, barely able to believe what she was doing. —She has been sabotaging the Horde and giving you information, all for you to win this battle.

However, with the dark sorceress so close, even Glimmer kept her power at the ready, telling herself she had to be lying.

—Alright, that's enough— Castaspella finally said, raising her hands to stop them three when she noticed that Shadow Weaver was getting increasingly angry at their animosity. —Come here— she told her, taking her a few steps away. —So… You never answered my question: Will you come with me now? This is no longer hypothetical, you know…

—Right…— she sighed, pretending to be resigned. —I'll go. But… You better keep those two away from me— she added, pointing at Glimmer and Angella.

—Oh, of course. They won't bite if you don't— Castaspella laughed.

A few hours later, the battle was finally over. The Rebellion had won. And the prisoners awaited the decision of the Princess Alliance about their fates. Princesses Entrapta and Scorpia waited with their hands still tied and a pair of guards overseeing them while, sitting nearby, Castaspella and Shadow Weaver waited on their own in front of the war room, completely free as they had willingly gone to Bright Moon with them.

The four of them knew what their chances were, and the only one likely to get a free pass was Castaspella. Except that the Princesses' discussion was taking far too long and they had yet to purge the black magic from the sorceress.

Just as Shadow Weaver feared, it soon showed signs of worsening as she began having issues breathing. She immediately recognized the corruption's effect despite Castaspella not having used black magic again, and realized she had little time before it became irreversible.

—Open up!— she exclaimed, banging on the door. —She won't last for long! You have to do something *now*! She's in terrible pain!

Hearing the scandal outside, the general guarding the door carefully opened it and immediately gasped seeing the sorceress on the ground, struggling to breathe, eyes tightly closed, and held by a desperate Shadow Weaver.

—Your Majesty, we have a situation here.

The Queen rushed to the door and, seeing how Castaspella couldn't even sit on her own, she decided it was better to cleanse the sorceress right there without further discussion.

While Castaspella rested, the Princesses finally arrived at a conclusion: Entrapta and Scorpia would be kept in Bright Moon, free to roam around but under constant vigilance; the sorceresses, however, were dismissed and sent to Mystacor for the Council to decide their fate. The Alliance decided to fully pardon Castaspella as it was proven that she had been the reason they defeated the Horde once and for all, but considered that Mystacor had to decide whether they would also forgive and forget her actions. Shadow Weaver, on the other hand, was sent there because Bright Moon and the other kingdoms regarded her as a prisoner, and only Mystacor had yet to decide what their position was.

Fortunately for them both, the Council immediately accepted Castaspella back as their Head Sorceress, glad to know she hadn't betrayed them after all, and thankful for her return as they had struggled to handle the kingdom while she was away. Because of that, Castaspella was free to decide Shadow Weaver's destiny and determined she'd be free within their kingdom, and that her actions would be her responsibility.

The following morning, the sorceresses were walking together around Mystacor and noticed how easily Castaspella had recovered everyone's trust. But her behaviour wasn't the same anymore: she now seemed more stern and determined, her usual gentleness was still there, but if she had to impose respect, she wouldn't hesitate a single moment; she wasn't afraid to stand her ground nor did she allow anything to shatter her confidence.

And, of course, she continued her little games with Shadow Weaver…

Once they found themselves alone, the dark sorceress corned her and teasingly asked — Where is Castahex now?

—May I remind you we can't do this just anywhere here? I'm the authority and have to set the example— Castaspella replied, although a mischievous smirk appeared on her lips.

—If it's a question of not being seen, then it's a good thing I know all of Mystacor's secret passages, no?

—Lead the way…

With a smirk, Shadow Weaver pressed her hand on the wall behind the sorceress and it opened to reveal a small empty room, illuminated by a few crystals on the walls. As soon as

they were inside, the wall closed behind them and they began kissing, pushing each other back to try and pin the other against the wall.

About an hour had gone by when they were interrupted by something like a knock on the entrance to the room, apparently known by whoever was on the other side, and the sorceresses were forced to stop.

However, Castaspella didn't jump to attend them as she would usually do; she had understood her times had to be respected too.

—Give me a moment, please— she replied, speaking loudly, as she needed time to let go of Shadow Weaver and tidy up her clothes a bit. She kissed the dark sorceress one last time and, stepping back, explained —Castahex may be gone, but I'm not the people-pleasing Castaspella I used to be either. Apparently that little role play, basically pretending to be you, taught me the difference between being senselessly cruel and merely imposing respect, between being a total jerk and simply setting boundaries. In a way, I suppose I learnt a few things from you. Now, you could well learn some from me, no?

Right after, she smirked and took a few steps back before turning around to leave the room. Being left alone, Shadow Weaver pushed her dress down and shook it a bit while deep in thought.

She couldn't help but reflect: does she really mean it? Could she learn from her? Did she *want to*?

Not at all.

She was great fun for sure, and served to take her head off from the failure of recovering Adora and Catra, by giving her a *new* objective.

But she couldn't fulfill that one either…

—A distraction. That's what she is. An entertaining one for sure— she told herself.

But that was *exactly* why she couldn't defeat her, turning her new purpose into an impossible endeavor, a senseless pursuit once again.

She only wanted to beat her, and yet, since that first night, she's overcome with lust by merely seeing her. She'd never be able to keep fighting her like that; if they were still on opposite sides, she'd be doomed.

The following day, as they woke up together in bed, Shadow Weaver grabbed her and complained —Traitor…

Right after, she pinned her down and sat on top of her before kissing down her neck towards her collarbone and continuing down her torso, scratching her slightly.

Quickly catching up on the teasing tone, she replied —Why now?

—I want Castahex back…

Castaspella laughed daintily and indulged her for a while until someone knocked on the door.

However, this time it was Shadow Weaver who answered, with a rude tone, —What is it!?

Whoever was at the other side of the door, hesitantly replied —We-we need the Head Sorceress… It's urgent!

Groaning in annoyance, the woman got off Castaspella and let her stand up to get dressed.

—A moment, please— she said, loud enough for the acolyte outside to hear her. She then addressed Shadow Weaver, gently reminding her —The fact that they went back to calling me Head Sorceress so quickly means they never replaced me even after weeks, and I pretty much left without telling anyone, which means they couldn't have known I was going to return. So, of course, they need a lot of help now.

—It's a miracle this council survived for so long without you… You should probably let Castahex "help", don't you think?

—Very funny— she replied, smirking before leaving the room. on her way to handle the issues she was called for, she stopped by the kitchen for a moment. —Can I ask to have breakfast prepared? For two. I will come to pick it up in a while— she requested. However, the cooks and helper acolytes stared at her in silence, seemingly shocked. So she insisted, more serious now —Was I not clear the first time? Or perhaps you have a hearing issue, in which case I suggest you go to see a physician as soon as possible.

The cooks immediately nodded and returned to work, giving orders to their helpers, and so Castaspella finally left, satisfied.

By the time she was done, she returned to her room with a tray full of food and a pair of steaming cups. Shadow Weaver's surprise was amusing to her, but she also noticed her unease and couldn't ignore it.

—What's the problem?

—The problem?— the dark sorceress scoffed, sardonic. —I shouldn't be here and you know it. People know who I am…

—Actually, many have no idea you were Light Spinner…

—Don't— she interrupted. —Everyone will know now that there's gossip all around… about us— she insisted.

—And I do not care about that— Castaspella sentenced. —This was my final decision and, if you're afraid the gossip will escalate things, then I'll just have to make sure everyone

understands…— she continued, grabbing her chin. —…That you cannot be touched.

Shadow Weaver knew what that meant. She would never defeat her now.

Not in this life…

Chapter End Notes

Well, that was all!
Were you expecting it? Be honest.
And, ofc, here's the link to the eliminated scenes of this chapter.

Three of them because I can and wanted ksjsj
But, seriously, thank you all for reading and I hope you enjoyed it.
This is to be considered a prequel to *You Were Mine to Kill*, and, if you may, the reason why SW was so obsessed with defeating Casta herself heh

ANYWAYS
Frye, it's finally done! Infinite thank-yous for the inspiration once again!!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!